VERMONT ACT 170

CHITTENDEN CENTRAL MERGER STUDY COMMITTEE #1

DRAFT MEETING MINUTES

Burlington School District | South Burlington School District | Winooski School District

Meeting Date: Tuesday, October 20, 2026 | 4:00 - 5:30 p.m.
Location: Winooski School District
Meeting Format: Hybrid — In-Person and Electronic Participation
Call to Order: Approximately 4:05 p.m.
Adjournment: 5:16 p.m.
Meeting Type: Initial Organizational Meeting
Status: DRAFT — Pending Committee Review and Approval

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1. Call to Order and Attendance

Craig Aarons-Martin, Regional Facilitator representing the Vermont Learning Collaborative (VTLC), convened the organizational meeting of the Chittenden Central Act 170 Merger Study Committee.

The meeting included representatives of Burlington, South Burlington, and Winooski, along with district personnel and members of the public participating in person and electronically.

Committee Representatives

Name	District	Role
Nicole Mace	Winooski	School Board President; elected Committee Chair
Clare Wool	Burlington	School Board Chair
Seamus Abshere	South Burlington	School Board Member

Other Participants Identified

Name	Role / Affiliation
Craig Aarons-Martin	Regional Facilitator, Vermont Learning Collaborative
Wilmer Chavarria	Superintendent, Winooski School District
Robert Millar	Winooski School Board Vice President; attending as a member of the public
Erik Johnson	Winooski School District, Technology
Sarah Haven	School representative
Michelle Boyer	Member of the public
Additional attendees	Participating in person and electronically

2. Act 170 Legislative Overview

The facilitator provided an overview of Act 170 and the committee's responsibilities.

The committee is charged with examining the advisability of establishing a unified union school district among the participating communities.

The study includes consideration of:

- Educational opportunities, student access, and equity
- Governance, transparency, and accountability
- Operational and financial implications
- Career and technical education
- Regional strengths, challenges, and opportunities
- Implications for participating school districts and their communities

The facilitator emphasized that Act 170 requires meaningful participation in the merger study process but does not require the committee to recommend a merger.

Members were informed that the study must result in a final report and recommendation by September 1, 2027.

The committee also reviewed subsequent state review requirements and possible voter consideration of a proposed merger.

No action was taken to recommend or approve a merger.

3. Committee Operating Principles

The facilitator introduced proposed operating principles to guide the committee's work.

Members discussed the following expectations:

1. **Lead with Students:** Center educational opportunity, student experience, access, and long-term outcomes.
2. **Challenge Ideas, Not Individuals:** Encourage rigorous examination of proposals while maintaining mutual respect.
3. **Use Evidence Before Conclusions:** Distinguish verified information from assumptions.
4. **Presume Good Faith:** Recognize that differing positions and disagreement are expected within the process.
5. **Honor Local Voice and Regional Responsibility:** Respect the interests of individual school districts while examining regional opportunities and responsibilities.
6. **Share Responsibility for Transparency:** Maintain communication with local boards, communities, and other stakeholders.

Seamus Abshere recommended that the principle of presuming good faith also extend to the legislators responsible for establishing the study process.

Members expressed general support for the proposed principles.

The facilitator agreed to circulate the presentation materials and invite additional suggested revisions.

Disposition: General consensus expressed. No formal vote on final written operating principles was recorded.

4. Good Faith Participation

The facilitator reviewed Vermont Learning Collaborative's working guidance regarding good-faith participation.

The discussion distinguished meaningful participation in the study from agreement with any particular merger outcome.

Members were advised that good-faith participation permits representatives to:

- Support or oppose a proposed merger.
- Challenge proposals, assumptions, or methodologies.
- Advocate for the interests of their communities.
- Consider alternatives and request additional evidence.
- Express disagreement during deliberations.

The discussion emphasized active participation, information sharing, communication with local boards, and compliance with applicable public meeting requirements.

Members expressed support for the framework presented.

Disposition: Discussion and general agreement. No separate formal action recorded.

5. Committee Organization and Election of Chair

The facilitator reviewed the responsibilities of committee leadership, including the chair's role in conducting meetings, recognizing motions, overseeing voting procedures, and coordinating agenda development with the facilitator.

Motion: Clare Wool nominated Nicole Mace of Winooski to serve as Chair of the Chittenden Central Act 170 Merger Study Committee.

Second: Seamus Abshere.

Vote: The nomination received unanimous approval among voting members present, as announced during the meeting.

Result: Nicole Mace was elected Committee Chair.

Members discussed the value of Nicole Mace's prior merger experience, familiarity with Vermont education law, and leadership experience.

The committee also recognized the significance of leadership representation from Winooski, the smallest of the three participating districts.

The facilitator will continue supporting committee organization, meeting preparation, information gathering, and the overall study process.

6. Committee Representation and Membership

The committee reviewed proportional representation among the three participating school districts.

The discussion focused on using long-term weighted membership, also described during the meeting as equalized pupil counts, rather than census population or average daily membership.

Two representation scenarios were presented:

School District	Scenario A	Scenario B
Winooski	1	2
South Burlington	2	3
Burlington	3	5
Total	**6**	**10**

Members discussed proportionality, the ability to maintain a quorum, and the practical considerations of scheduling a larger committee.

Clare Wool indicated that Burlington had considered five representatives but was open to a smaller delegation consistent with the proportional framework.

Following discussion, Nicole Mace and Clare Wool expressed agreement with **Scenario A**, consisting of six representatives:

- Winooski: 1
- South Burlington: 2
- Burlington: 3

The facilitator was asked to include the underlying weighted-pupil calculations, prepared by Wilmer Chavarria, in the public meeting materials.

Seamus Abshere departed the meeting before the committee completed its proportional-representation discussion.

Disposition: The transcript reflects agreement with the 1–2–3 structure. A formal motion, second, and recorded vote were not identified. This action should be confirmed during review of the minutes.

Districts will confirm their respective representative appointments.

7. Meeting Schedule and Locations

The committee discussed establishing a predictable meeting schedule that accommodates existing school board meetings and school vacation periods.

Members identified conflicts with regular school board meetings, particularly on Wednesdays.

Following discussion, members agreed to establish a regular meeting cadence of the **first Monday of each month at 4:00 p.m.**

Meetings will generally be held in person, with locations rotating among the participating school districts. Electronic meetings may be scheduled as circumstances require.

Upcoming Meetings

Date	Time	Location / Format
Monday, November 2, 2026	4:00 p.m.	Virtual
Monday, December 7, 2026	4:00 p.m.	Champlain Elementary School, Burlington

Members discussed whether to defer the November meeting because of district budget development and anticipated state data releases.

The committee expressed a preference for maintaining the November meeting to continue the study and exchange available district information.

Clare Wool offered to coordinate the December meeting at Champlain Elementary School.

Disposition: Meeting schedule established by consensus. No formal motion or vote was recorded.

8. Public Communication and Meeting Documentation

The committee discussed procedures for public meeting notices, minutes, recordings, and access to study materials.

The facilitator outlined the following administrative expectations:

- Provide agendas at least 48 hours before regularly scheduled meetings.
- Provide advance notice of special meetings consistent with applicable requirements.
- Prepare draft meeting minutes within five calendar days.

- Share recording links as soon as available.
- Maintain a centralized collection of committee materials.
- Make approved minutes and supporting public records accessible.

Members discussed opportunities to reduce duplication while ensuring that residents can locate committee information through their respective school districts.

The committee expressed support for using a centralized repository while maintaining appropriate district-level notices and links.

Dedicated Committee Website

Seamus Abshere proposed establishing a dedicated website for the Chittenden Central Act 170 study.

He offered to assist with website development and maintenance and estimated the annual cost at approximately $100.

Clare Wool suggested that the expense should be incorporated into facilitation resources rather than funded personally by a committee member.

Craig Aarons-Martin agreed to consult with VTLC Lead Facilitator Dave Younce regarding available funding and coordinate further with Seamus Abshere.

Disposition: Website proposal discussed. Funding and implementation remain pending. No expenditure was authorized.

9. Regional Asset Mapping and Study Preparation

The committee discussed the focus of its November meeting.

Members expressed interest in beginning the study with an examination of each district's existing strengths, programs, resources, partnerships, and financial commitments.

The facilitator introduced a regional asset-mapping approach to help members understand current educational opportunities before evaluating potential governance configurations.

Initial topics identified included:

- Academic programs and curricular offerings
- Career and technical education
- Arts, enrichment, and extracurricular opportunities
- Special education and student support services
- Innovation and technology partnerships

- Student belonging and community identity
- District leadership and governance structures
- School facilities and capital investments
- Existing financial obligations and debt service

Clare Wool emphasized the importance of considering financial obligations and debt service alongside district assets.

Members also discussed the need to distinguish between information expected from the Vermont Agency of Education and information that participating districts would need to provide directly.

Craig Aarons-Martin agreed to consult with Dave Younce and distribute a proposed asset-mapping template and initial data expectations.

Each district will begin preparing information for the committee's November discussion.

10. Committee Member Orientation

Clare Wool offered to share a committee orientation resource developed in connection with the Taconic and Green/Rutland merger study process.

The document outlines committee-member roles, responsibilities, governance expectations, and working norms.

Members discussed the value of using a common orientation resource as additional representatives join the committee.

The facilitator and committee chair will review the resource for potential adaptation.

Disposition: Resource offered for review. No formal adoption recorded.

11. Public Participation

Members of the public attended the meeting in person and electronically.

Robert Millar and Michelle Boyer were among the public attendees acknowledged during introductions.

The supplied transcript does not document a distinct public-comment period containing substantive public testimony.

Public comments received: To be confirmed from the official meeting record.

12. Follow-Up Actions

Responsibility	Assigned To	Timeline
Circulate meeting presentation and draft minutes	Craig Aarons-Martin	Following meeting
Establish and maintain shared committee materials repository	Craig Aarons-Martin	Ongoing
Distribute regional asset-mapping template	Craig Aarons-Martin	By October 23
Clarify state-provided versus district-provided information	Craig Aarons-Martin / Dave Younce	Before November meeting
Provide weighted-pupil analysis supporting committee representation	Winooski district representatives / Wilmer Chavarria	With meeting records
Confirm website funding and coordinate potential development	Craig Aarons-Martin / Dave Younce / Seamus Abshere	Pending
Share committee-member orientation resource	Clare Wool	Before November meeting
Prepare preliminary district asset and financial information	Participating district representatives	November meeting
Confirm appointments and membership	Participating school boards	As needed

13. Adjournment

Following discussion of November meeting preparation, the facilitator thanked participants and concluded the organizational meeting.

Adjournment time: 5:16 p.m.

No formal motion or vote to adjourn was identified in the transcript.

Official Meeting Record

Minutes Prepared By:
Craig Aarons-Martin
Regional Facilitator
Vermont Learning Collaborative

Date Prepared: October 23, 2026

Status: Draft — Pending Review and Approval

Date Approved: _____

Local Recording: Meeting records Transcript Recording

Supporting Documents: Meeting agenda, presentation

These draft minutes document committee proceedings and actions based on the available meeting transcript and notes. They are subject to correction and formal approval by the committee.